POSTCARD LANDING PAGES · RECOMMENDATION

Should we hide our email addresses?

You asked whether publishing `enquiries@langcen.cam.ac.uk` as a clickable email link on the postcard landing pages invites spam, and whether we should obscure it. This is my answer and the evidence behind it.

Prepared **15 September 2026** Pages reviewed **10** Email links audited **12**

The decision: should we hide the email addresses?

My recommendation is to leave them exactly as they are — ordinary clickable email links, with the address itself as the visible text — and to take the spam concern seriously somewhere it can actually be fixed.

The worry is that scrapers will harvest `enquiries@langcen.cam.ac.uk` from these pages, and it is a fair one: each address is a clickable `mailto:` link, which is the easiest thing on any web page for a harvesting program to spot. Three things nonetheless argue against acting on it here:

- **The address is already published elsewhere on our own website.** The main Language Centre site publishes it openly, alongside `culp@` and `adtis@`. Hiding it on ten postcard pages protects an address anyone can still collect from the main site in the same afternoon.
- **The alternatives either don't work or cost us something real.** Encoding the address in the HTML is undone by any program that reads the page. Reversing it with styling defeats simple scrapers but corrupts what screen readers announce and what "copy email address" puts on the clipboard — an accessibility problem on a University site. Assembling it in JavaScript works against lazy bots, but means the contact route disappears entirely if the page's script fails to load.
- **Spam to a shared inbox is a mail-filtering problem.** That inbox receives mail prompted by the printed cards, the main website and the staff directory alike. Filtering in front of it addresses all of those; markup on ten pages addresses a fraction of one.

I looked for a general enquiries form to point the two buttons at instead, which would have sidestepped the question. There doesn't appear to be one — the Language Centre publishes addresses rather than a form. The only form I found is the specific conversation-exchange one, which isn't a general contact route. If a general form does exist, send me the address and I'll reconsider.

One point that settles it in favour of email: you asked whether a subject line could be filled in automatically. With an email link that is free and reliable — it's already done, as above. With a web form it only works if the form was built to accept it, which we can't assume and I couldn't verify.

If you'd still like something done, the honest next step is asking whoever runs the mail domain what filtering currently sits in front of that inbox.

Where the email address appears

An audit of every email link on the live pages. All twelve use the same correct address; none were broken or out of date.

LOCATION	APPEARS AS	REACH
Shared footer	the address itself	All 10 pages
Language advising	“Email us to book your appointment”	1 page
Visit our Study Centre	“Email the Study Centre”	1 page

The two buttons spell the address out rather than taking it from the shared setting, deliberately: they are each page's main way of getting in touch, and must keep working even if the page's script fails. That's now written down in the code beside the shared setting, naming both pages, so a future address change can't quietly miss them.